

facility, the recovery of a barrel grenade launcher, two air rifles, two muzzle-loading weapons, one 12-bore gun, three INSAS magazines, one telescope, two generators, nine bench clamping, drilling and punching machines and Maoist uniforms and literature. Four suspected Maoists—Aaytu Nureti, Suresh Nuruti, Budhuram Padda and Manoj Hichami—were arrested after an encounter on January 16 in Kanker district. Another deputy commander-level Maoist, Ratan Kashyap alias Salaam, was killed in a separate encounter in the Mangnar forests in the Bastar district the same day (see *Op Surya Shakti*).

Surya Shakti is only the first of many operations that are part of the Centre's larger strategy to intensify action against the Maoists in Chhattisgarh, particularly in the Bastar region. This is where seven of the state's 14 LWE-affected districts lie—Bastar, Kanker, Kondagaon, Dantewada, Narayanpur, Bijapur and Sukma. Field commanders have reportedly been given a green signal to step up operations. Three battalions of the BSF will also be moved from Odisha's Malkangiri to Chhattisgarh and an equal number of ITBP (Indo-Tibetan Police Force) units moved further inland into Abujhmad as part of the area domination exercise. One BSF battalion has already been directed to create six new COBs or company operating bases in Narayanpur district, according to news reports. The ITBP, which currently has about eight battalions in the Narayanpur, Rajnandgaon and Kondagaon districts, has been asked to move a unit further into the core area, where the security vacuum has allowed armed Maoists to recoup. In all, nine new security camps have been set up in South Bastar in the past couple of months, and security forces have been engaging Maoists in the Bijapur, Sukma and Narayanpur fronts.

According to government data, incidents of Naxal violence have come down by 52 per cent, deaths by 70 per cent and the number of overall affected districts from 96 to 45 in the past 10 years. The Centre also believes that the Maoist leadership is getting old and decimated progressively, which is why a strong push could mean the end.

Others would caution against any such complacency. The Dandakaranya Special Zonal Committee, where the top CPI (Maoist) leadership is concentrated, continues to supply cadre and senior- and middle-rung leaders to other states, be it to the Telangana state committee or the Andhra-Odisha border special zonal committee. The complete security vacuum in Abujhmad is enabling armed Maoist cadre to train, operate and move here from across the Chhattisgarh-Odisha border. At the same time, the increased focus of the security forces in Bastar has led to the Maoists carving out new zones of operations, prominent among them being the MMC or the Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh zone, and the KKT or the Kerala, Karnataka and Tamil Nadu zone.

The Maoists also remain the masters of covert or guerrilla offensive, setting up improvised explosive devices (IEDs) to catch security forces unawares and inflict heavy casualties. There is no technology yet to detect IEDs. They also continue to recruit tribal villagers in their *jan* militias to carry out subversive activities.

This is the reason why those overseeing operations are cautious about claiming any success. Ask them if there has been an increase in the number of 'engagements' after the new government has taken over, and a senior police officer in south Chhattisgarh is willing to concede only this much: "The reason for the increase in engagements between the forces and Maoists is that we are planning more operations. The more the operations, the more the chances of engagements."

So what of the charges of a lull in operations during the previous regime in the state? Was Chhattisgarh the least active in anti-Maoist operations in the MMC zone, even as the MP and Maharashtra police went all-out, the latter even eliminating high-value Maoists?

Police officers say new security camps were set up and operations were conducted between 2018 and 2023, but they were very few in numbers. The commanders were certainly less

OP SURYA SHAKTI

- **Conducted between Jan. 12 and 16 in Urchapal, Paraidhi, Pangur, Tekameta, Musparse and Kukur villages, among others**
- **Joint op by Special Task Force (STF), District Reserve Guards (DRG) and Border Security Force (BSF) personnel**
- **4 Maoists arrested on Jan. 16 after encounter in Kanker district–Aaytu Nureti, 26; Suresh Nuruti, 25; Budhuram Padda, 25 and Manoj Hichami, 22**
- **1 Maoist–Todma militia platoon deputy commander, Ratan Kashyap alias Salaam, 31, killed in encounter in Bastar district**